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From the editor-in-chief

It is a hard fact but nobody in the world is immune to cancer. Each of us knows someone, either family or friend, who has suffered from cancer, survived it or succumbed to it. In our time, cancer became to modern medicine what the black plague was to the Middle Ages, a disease that could neither be prevented nor cured.

For the last four decades, doctors and scientists have been battling cancer at every level: to suggest means of its prevention, control its spread and to tackle its worst stages. Every year drugs that handle even the slightest aspect of cancer are being added to modern medicine's ammunition against the dreaded disease even as research improves our understanding of how cancer works. For all the brutality of the treatment and its harsh side-effects, chemotherapy and radiotherapy have saved many lives.

It has been a very long and hard struggle for both doctors and patients but neither side has given up. The war is not yet over but the gains from many battles have been significant.

Both in India and in the rest of the world, there has been an increase of new research, drugs and treatments for cancer. The survival rate for all cancers globally has gone up from 50 per cent in 1975 to 66 per cent today. The survival rates are now highest for cancers of the prostate, breast, bladder and kidney, to name a few. Childhood leukemia, which killed 75 per cent of patients in the 1970s, now has a survival rate of 73 per cent.

Yes, some cancers like those of the lung and the pancreas remain difficult to tackle but every year, there is progress being made in other aspects of the disease. In India, the survival rates are going up as well, especially for prostate, breast and children's cancers. Innovative surgeries are carried out in our hospitals, some of which offer cutting edge radiotherapy of a kind not available in the rest of South Asia. A clinical trial at Mumbai's Tata Memorial Hospital to develop molecules that attack and kill cancer cells and spare the good ones has produced promising results. The best cancer hubs in India are accessible to the masses as they are subsidised by the government and the growth of the generic drug market promises to bring down the costs of the cures.

Our cover story this week is an in-depth look into the war on cancer and the significant territory being covered to tackle what a few generations ago used to be considered a death sentence.

The story is written by Deputy Editor Damayanti Datta whose interest in the subject grew when a friend in the US was diagnosed with a grade 4 brain cancer. Talking to doctors and experts in the field led her to understand the new developments around treatment of the disease and to realise that "the dread is going out of the C-word". A leading AIIMS oncologist who had spent three decades in the battle against the disease told Datta that he was "hoping to see a definitive cure for cancer over the next 15 years".

I hope those words are prophetic.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR NOVEMBER
2000 COVER